48.4

PER CENT

of Mumbai's 10.2 million population lives in slums



MILIND SHELTE

WITH THE LOK SABHA AND STATE ASSEMBLY polls in 2024 drawing near, the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena-Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) government in Maharashtra is going all-out to woo the powerful slum-dweller vote bank in Mumbai. The state government has decided to allot apartments in slum redevelopment schemes at Rs 2.5 lakh to residents of shanties that have come up between 2000 and 2011. It is estimated that this will cover around 1.6-1.8 million people as their slums are redeveloped in the coming years. Slum-dwellers whose houses were constructed before 2000 are legally protected and eligible for free housing. Many are housed in 300 square feet flats under Slum Rehabilitation Authority (SRA) projects.

In 2018, the BJP-Sena coalition under Devendra Fadnavis decided to rehabilitate and grant houses to residents of shanties built between January 1, 2000 and January 1, 2011 at an appropriate cost. In May 2023, a government resolution was issued, fixing the price of a tenement at Rs 2.5 lakh. Sources from the Maharashtra state housing department say that, initially, the plan was to charge residents on the basis of the cost of construction. But since this would work out to Rs 8 lakh-Rs 12 lakh for a 300 sq. ft house in a highrise, it was fixed at Rs 2.5 lakh.

The state cabinet has also approved a decision to reduce the lock-in period for the sale of free SRA rehabilitation tenements from 10 to seven years; a bill is expected to be tabled in the legislature soon. This means that individuals who have been given flats free of cost can sell them after seven years. SRA officials admit that despite the lock-in period, beneficiaries continued to sell flats or clandestinely create third-party rights. In 2021, a survey of 86,429 tenements by the SRA found that 10,983 were occupied by unauthorised entities. The state government has also approved in principle a policy of covering residents on the first floor of chawls located in slums under SRA schemes. At present, only those on the ground floor are eligible for rehabilitation. Officials say this policy will apply to around 2,000 chawls built before January 1, 1976, housing an estimated 18,000 residents, largely in Mumbai's western and eastern suburbs such as Malad, Kanjurmarg, Ghatkopar and Bhandup. "Since these first-floor residents were not covered under SRA norms, thousands were rendered homeless," says Gopal Shetty, the BJP MP from North Mumbai who had taken up the issue with the government. "Builders paid them modest amounts like Rs 10 lakh, and they would shift to far-off places like Vasai, Virar and Nalasopara."

The state housing department is also working on a policy to allow government agencies like the Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority (MHADA) or the City and Industrial Development Corporation (CIDCO) launch or complete work on stalled SRA projects where private developers have shown little interest.

A LEGACY ISSUE

Bombay's slums are as old as modern-day Mumbai. They began sprouting since the beginning of the 20th century, with the arrival of thousands of economic migrants from across Maharashtra and India. Gradually, informal settlements like Dharavi or the Matunga labour camp took the shape of today's slums. The city has 2,583 slum clusters, with around 1.2 million structures. Today, of Mumbai's 34,000-acre approximate area, around 8,333.5 acres, or 24 per cent, is covered by slums. An estimated 48.4 per cent of Mumbai's 124 million population (as per the 2011 census) lives in these densely-populated areas. Importantly, slum-dwellers are enthusiastic voters.

LAND OWNERSHIP IN SLUMS

